

“ I OWNED THE WORLD THAT HOUR AS I RODE OVER IT... ”

Charles Lindbergh, American aviator



Aviator Charles Lindbergh poses alongside the *Spirit of St. Louis*, the aircraft in which he achieved the first nonstop flight from New York to Paris.

IN MAY 1927, 25-YEAR-OLD CHARLES LINDBERGH (1902–1974) **flew solo across the Atlantic**, a feat that made him the most famous American alive. The offer of a cash prize for the first nonstop flight between New York and Paris had stimulated feverish competition. On May 8, famous French war aces Charles Nungesser and François Coli attempted the flight from Paris; they set off westward over the Atlantic and were never seen again. Such dramas had wrought excitement to a high pitch when the unknown Lindbergh, an airmail pilot, took off from Roosevelt Field on May 20 aboard a custom-built monoplane. Not only did he succeed in reaching **Paris in 33 hours and 30 minutes**, but he did it alone. Lindbergh was mobbed on landing in France and the mixed blessing of celebrity accompanied him for the rest of



The Great Mississippi Flood
Following months of heavy rain, the Mississippi broke its levees in spring 1927, submerging a vast area of land (in purple) and killing 246 people.

his life. His achievement stimulated the rapid growth of commercial aviation in the US.

America's upbeat mood was ripe for the world's **first modern consumer boom**, which was built around the purchase of cars and electrical goods. By 1927, there was one car for every six Americans—enough to ensure that even quite modest families might aspire to a Model T Ford. Levels of saving were high, and many chose to invest their spare cash in the rising stock market.

Not everything was as positive, however. **Falling prices for agricultural goods** were hitting rural areas worldwide, and the US, with almost half its population working the land, was not immune. Farm owners were heavily in debt and farm workers were badly paid.

The terrible conditions experienced by many rural workers was highlighted in April 1927 by the **Great Mississippi**

Flood, which was the worst flood disaster in American history. Many of its victims were black and very poor; ill-treated and neglected in refugee camps after the disaster, many thousands of them swelled the movement of African-Americans from the south to new lives in northern cities.

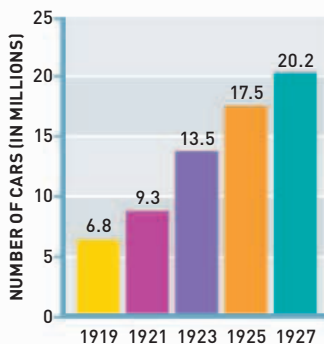
Two of the greatest works in cinema history were released in 1927: Fritz Lang's futuristic *Metropolis* and Abel Gance's historical epic *Napoleon*. But these hugely ambitious silent movies were upstaged by the success of Al Jolson (1886–1950) in a sound film, *The Jazz Singer*. A new era of “**talkies**” had arrived.

Second only to the Lindbergh flight in media coverage in 1927 was the controversy surrounding the **execution of the anarchists** Ferdinando **Sacco** and Bartolomeo **Vanzetti**. Italian immigrants dubiously convicted of a murder in Massachusetts in 1920, their case became a focus of protests by liberals and socialists, and their execution by electric chair on August 23 provoked riots in a number of cities across the world.

Meanwhile, in the Soviet Union, **Leon Trotsky**

(1879–1940) was expelled from the central committee of the ruling Communist Party in November, along with his allies Grigori Zinoviev and Lev Kamenev. Once the favorite to succeed Lenin (1870–1924) as Soviet leader, Trotsky had been ruthlessly outmaneuvered by the party's General Secretary Joseph

Stalin (1878–1953). Accused of “factionalism,” Trotsky was sent into internal exile in Kazakhstan the following January and finally **expelled from the Soviet Union** in February 1929. Zinoviev and Kamenev submitted to Stalin, but he had them executed in 1936.



Car ownership in the US

In the eight years from 1919 to 1927 the number of cars on America's roads tripled. Five-sixths of the world's automobiles were in the US.



First feature-length “talkie”

The first successful full-length sound feature film, *The Jazz Singer*, took \$2.6 million at American box offices and made Jolson a household name.

